

What is Hypertension?

Hypertension, commonly known as high blood pressure, is a chronic condition in which the force of blood against artery walls is consistently too high. It affects over 1.13 billion people globally and is often called the “silent killer” because it may not show symptoms for years while damaging vital organs.

Types of Hypertension

1. Primary (Essential) Hypertension

- Most common form, develops gradually over time without a specific cause.
- Linked to lifestyle, genetics, and aging.

2. Secondary Hypertension

- Caused by underlying conditions such as kidney disease, hormonal disorders, or use of certain medications (e.g., birth control pills, decongestants).
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Risk Factors

- Family history
 - Obesity or being overweight
 - Excess salt or alcohol intake
 - Physical inactivity
 - Smoking
 - Stress
 - Chronic kidney disease or diabetes
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Symptoms

Often asymptomatic, but when present:

- Headaches
 - Shortness of breath
 - Nosebleeds
 - Fatigue or confusion
 - Chest pain
 - Vision problems
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Complications

If left untreated, hypertension can lead to:

- Stroke
 - Heart attack
 - Heart failure
 - Kidney damage
 - Vision loss
 - Cognitive decline
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Diagnosis

1. Blood Pressure Monitoring

- Normal: <120/80 mmHg
- Hypertension Stage 1: 130–139/80–89 mmHg
- Stage 2: ≥140/90 mmHg

2. Ambulatory Blood Pressure Monitoring (ABPM)

- Tracks blood pressure over 24 hours.
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Treatment and Management

• Lifestyle Changes

- Low-sodium diet (DASH diet)
- Regular physical activity
- Stress reduction
- Limiting alcohol and quitting smoking

• Medications

- ACE inhibitors, ARBs, beta blockers, diuretics

• Monitoring

- Home BP devices and regular checkups
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References

- World Health Organization (WHO)
- American Heart Association (AHA)

- <https://www.cdc.gov/bloodpressure>
- <https://www.heart.org/en/health-topics/high-blood-pressure>